

Move to Milwaukee

The Relocation Guide

Your step-by-step resource for moving, living and buying a home in Metro Milwaukee — whether you're considering a fresh start from Chicago, exploring Midwest opportunities, or simply after a better quality of life.

LUCAS MURPHY · eXp Realty

REALTOR® · ABR® · PSA

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Welcome to Milwaukee

Where affordability meets lifestyle

Thousands relocate here each year — most from Chicago, the coasts and other Midwest metros — drawn by affordability, lifestyle and a sense of community that is hard to find in larger cities.

Milwaukee offers the amenities and culture of a major metro without the costs and congestion. From the lakefront to thriving neighbourhoods, a world-class arts scene to championship sports.

1,762

Net annual inflow from Chicago

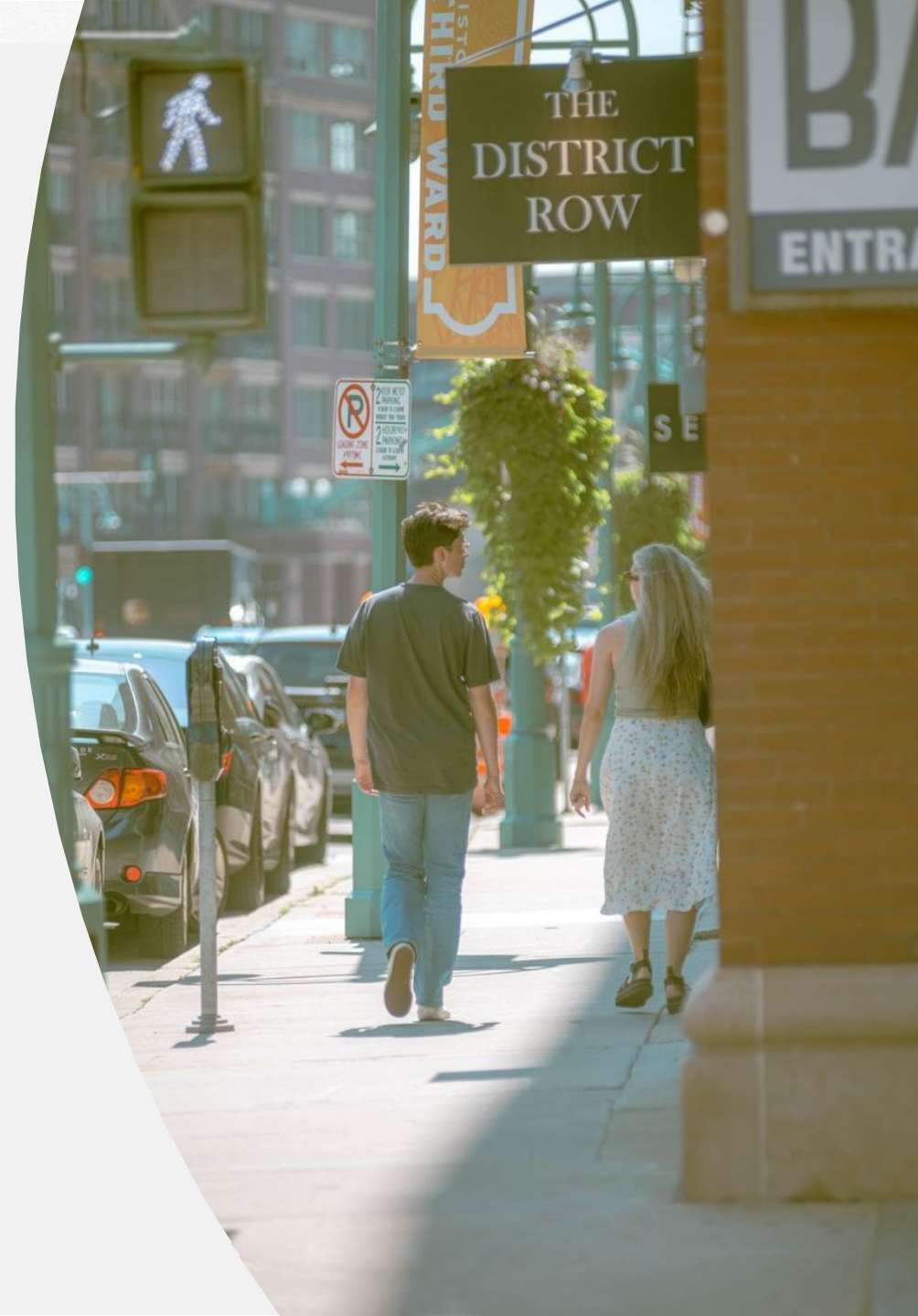
Redfin, 2025

27.8%

Lower cost of living than
Chicago

47%

Lower rent





Why people are moving here

Affordability

Homes run 30–40% cheaper than Chicago. Your housing budget stretches further, so you get more space, better neighbourhoods, and equity sooner.

Lifestyle

Lakefront access, vibrant arts and music, craft breweries, and a strong sense of community.

Jobs

Healthcare, technology and manufacturing provide diverse careers. Major employers are expanding and remote work is abundant.

Location

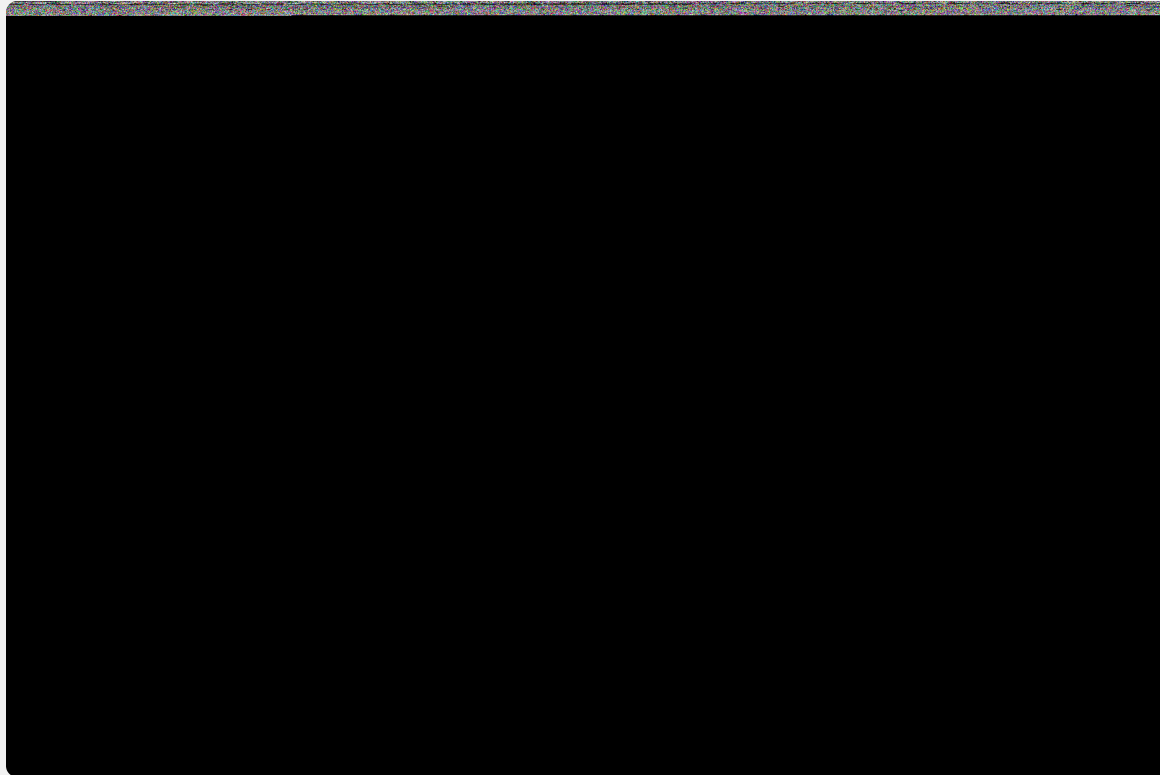
90 minutes to Chicago. Close enough for visits, far enough for lower costs and a calmer pace.

- ❑ A \$400,000 home in Milwaukee would cost roughly \$700,000 for comparable features and location in Chicago.

Milwaukee vs. Chicago

Category	Milwaukee	Chicago	Diff
Cost of living index	100	127.8	+27.8%
Monthly rent	\$1,192–1,839	\$1,692–2,788	+47%
Groceries index	100	119.4	+19.4%
Price per sq ft	\$179	\$338	+88%

The bottom line. A \$6,000-a-month lifestyle in Milwaukee would take \$7,667 in Chicago — nearly \$20,000 a year in savings you can invest, save or simply enjoy.



Meet your local expert

LUCAS MURPHY — REALTOR® · ABR®
· PSA · eXp Realty

I work with out-of-state buyers relocating to Milwaukee, from the first Zoom consultation to the closing table and beyond.

My approach combines local market knowledge with an understanding of what relocating actually involves — I know the questions you have and the challenges ahead, because they come up on every out-of-state purchase.

Whether you're exploring neighbourhoods virtually, coordinating inspections remotely, or planning a discovery weekend, I'll be your advocate throughout.

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Neighbourhoods to explore

Wauwatosa

Family-friendly and central. Strong schools, a walkable village, easy highway access. Median \$427,500.

Shorewood

Historic, tree-lined, direct lake access. Walkable downtown and architectural variety. Median \$590,000.

Brookfield

Spacious and upscale. Top-rated schools, large lots, excellent shopping. Median \$550,000.

Bay View

Artsy, walkable, lakefront charm. Cafés, breweries and KK River dining, close to downtown.

East Side and Downtown

Urban and energetic. Walkable to entertainment, dining and the lakefront.

Municipality medians are August 2026. Bay View and the East Side sit inside the City of Milwaukee, whose median is \$252,000 — neighbourhood pricing within the city varies widely, so ask me for a read on the specific pocket you're considering.

Schools, lifestyle and community

Top public districts

Brookfield, Whitefish Bay, Wauwatosa, and the Nicolet High School District.

Premier private options

Marquette University High School, Divine Savior Holy Angels, University School of Milwaukee, and a diverse parochial network.

Attractions

Summerfest, the world's largest music festival. The Milwaukee Art Museum and Third Ward galleries. The Bucks at Fiserv Forum. Brewers baseball at American Family Field.

Outdoors

More than 150 parks across the county, the 125-mile Oak Leaf Trail, the Milwaukee County Zoo, and Lake Michigan beaches and harbours.



Housing market snapshot

City of Milwaukee — August 2026

Metric	2025	2026	Change
Median sale price	\$249,900	\$252,000	+0.8%
Days on market	17	21	+23.5%
Pct of orig. list received	101.1%	100.0%	−1.1%
New listings	447	538	+20.4%
Closed sales	331	328	−0.9%

What it means. New listings are up sharply and homes are taking a few days longer to sell, which gives buyers more choice and a little more room than a year ago. Sellers are still getting essentially their full asking price, so this is a healthier market rather than a soft one.

Source: RapidStats, August 2026. Figures move monthly — ask me for the current read on your target area.

Your six-step move plan

01

Discovery call

Lifestyle priorities, budget, timeline and must-haves, so we only look at what fits.

03

Virtual tours

Personalised video walkthroughs, so you get a genuine feel for a property before you travel.

05

Inspection and closing

Coordinated with vetted inspectors, lenders and title companies, with support at every checkpoint from out of state.

02

Neighbourhood match

Neighbourhood profiles, school information, commute analysis and lifestyle fit.

04

Offer and negotiation

Local market data behind a strategic offer that positions you to win without overpaying.

06

Welcome home

Vendor recommendations, utility setup and neighbourhood introductions.



Your trusted local network

One of the hardest parts of relocating is not knowing who to trust.
You are never required to use any of them. The point is that you don't start from scratch.



Jobs and economy

Healthcare

Froedtert Health, Aurora Health Care, Children's Wisconsin, the Medical College of Wisconsin. The largest employment sector, consistently expanding.

Technology

Generac, Northwestern Mutual's digital hub, Johnson Controls, Rockwell Automation. Lower living costs attract talent from more expensive markets.

Manufacturing

Harley-Davidson, Rockwell Automation, Johnson Controls, Briggs & Stratton. A modern renaissance built on automation.

Education

Marquette, Milwaukee School of Engineering, UW-Milwaukee, Milwaukee Public Schools.

□ That diversity is what creates resilience.

Cost-saving resources

Down payment assistance

WHEDA programs, first-time buyer grants, FHA at 3.5% down, conventional from 3%, and VA at 0% for eligible veterans. *Terms and availability change through the year; confirm current status before relying on any of them.*

Tax benefits

Homestead exemption, Wisconsin mortgage interest deduction, property tax credits, and energy efficiency rebates.

Utilities

We Energies for electric and gas, Milwaukee Water Works, Spectrum and AT&T for internet. A complete transfer checklist is included.

Moving and settling

Vetted movers, storage, home warranty options, vendor directories, and school registration help.



The relocation toolkit



Cost of living calculator

Compare your current city to Milwaukee.



Neighbourhood fit quiz

Find which areas match your priorities.



Home buying timeline

Milestones and what to expect at each stage.



Vendor directory

Trusted professionals for every service.



Discovery weekend itinerary

A schedule to make the most of a visit.



School comparison guide

District and private school profiles.



Chicago vs. Milwaukee budget sheet

A detailed expense comparison across housing, transport, dining and entertainment.

Your move. Your Milwaukee.

Let's make it happen.

From Chicago to Cream City — I'll help you make the move with confidence, clarity and support at every step.

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